For the next year, he remained in Kandahar, surrounded by his milk mothers, kokas (milk brothers), and foster fathers. As the young child grew up realizing he was effectively a hostage of his uncles while his parents remained untraceable, it was not surprising that as a young man he would have an unassailable faith in these foster families and would speak of a ‘river of milk’, a precious bond that he would never betray. For many of these women, Turki was their native language and Akbar would have grown up hearing this language spoken around him in addition to courtly Persian and the Arabic of the Koran. Akbar remembered an incident decades later in which Maham Anaga reminded Askari of a Turki custom in which when a child first learns to walk, his father strikes the child with his turban, causing him to fall, thus warding off the evil eye. Askari agreed to perform this duty in lieu of his absent brother and Akbar reminisced that ‘this striking and falling, are visibly before me’.

When Kamran heard in the winter of 1544 that Humayun was marching back towards Kandahar, he understood that the circumstances had irrevocably changed. Unlike the fugitive Padshah he had hounded out of Hindustan, this Humayun was now returning at the head of 14,000 horsemen with the blessings of the Shah of Persia himself. Included among the troops were noblemen of distinguished lineage, outstanding for their bravery, who would hold high positions later at Akbar’s court such as the Uzbek chief, Haidar Sultan Shaibani, and his sons, Ali Quli Khan and Bahadur Khan. It was at this critical juncture that Askari panicked and when he received his brother Kamran’s demand for Humayun’s children, he hastily sent Akbar and his half-sister Bakshi Banu on their perilous journey to Kabul. There they were reunited with the elderly Khanzada Begum, who wept as she held the cherished boy in her arms and kissed his hands and feet. ‘They are the very hands and feet of my brother the Emperor Babur,’ sobbed the old woman, who still grieved for her beloved younger brother, dead fourteen years previously. ‘He is like him altogether.’ Also present in Kabul were Akbar’s young aunt, Gulbadan, his stepmother, Bega Begum, who had been sent back by Sher Shah Sur, and several of Babur’s widows. The children spent a few months in Kabul with Kamran and Akbar remembered another episode that dated back to this time. A kettledrum had been gifted to Kamran’s son, Mirza Ibrahim, but the young Akbar wanted it too. Kamran thought it would be amusing to have the boys wrestle for the drum, no doubt counting on the strength of his older son to defeat Akbar